

PrEP FAQs

What is PrEP?

“PrEP” stands for Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis. The word “prophylaxis” means to prevent or control the spread of an infection or disease. The goal of PrEP is to prevent HIV infection from taking hold if you are exposed to the virus. This is done by taking one pill every day. These are some of the same medicines used to keep the virus under control in people who are already living with HIV. For HIV negative people who take it every day, PrEP can lower the risk of getting HIV by 92%–99%. One recent study following over 600 men who have sex with men in San Francisco in a two and a half year period, reported that there were zero new HIV diagnoses among those on PrEP.

In July of 2012, the CDC (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) officially released a statement recommending once-daily PrEP pills for individuals who are at high risk for HIV - infection and to be used in combination with other safe sex practices.

Current research is being conducted on other PrEP treatments (i.e., on-demand, intermittent, long-acting injectable), but once-daily is the only dosage currently approved by the FDA (US Food & Drug Administration) and recommended by the CDC.

In May of 2018, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) approved PrEP, in combination with safer sex practices, to reduce the risk of HIV in at-risk adolescents.

Who should take PrEP?

If you are HIV negative and want to protect yourself from HIV, PrEP may be right for you:

If you don't always use a condom

If you have multiple sex partners

If you have an HIV-Positive partner

Is PrEP safe?

PrEP (brand name “Truvada”), has been shown to be very safe. However, PrEP can have mild side effects, like stomach pain, weight loss and headaches, especially at the beginning of treatment. Rare side effects include kidney or bone problems. Only a small number of people found the side effects serious enough to stop taking the medication. Lab tests to monitor kidney functions every six months are part of the medical protocol for PrEP. People who are on PrEP, or considering PrEP, should discuss possible side effects with their medical provider and weigh side effects against the potential benefits of PrEP in reducing the chance of HIV infection and the resulting life-long antiretroviral treatment.

What can I expect if begin taking PrEP?

CDC guidelines require individuals who take PrEP to visit a medical provider once every 3 months not including the couple of follow-ups once you start. Below is the schedule of medical appointments for people who want to take PrEP:

First Appointment: This first appointment includes education about PrEP, a discussion about your readiness to take PrEP, HIV testing and, if ready, medication is prescribed for a 30-day period.

One Month Follow-Up: At the first follow-up appointment one month later, the provider will discuss your experience on PrEP including adherence, side effects and your interest in continuing. At this visit, a prescription for 60 days may be given.

Three Month Follow-Up: At this visit, HIV testing and STD screening are conducted. The provider will review the importance of adherence and provide support for taking the medication every day. At this visit, a prescription for 90 days may be given.

Every Three Months: HIV testing and other assessments are repeated every three months. If you remain HIV negative and express continued commitment to take the medication daily, a prescription for 90 days may be given every three months for as long as you prefer.

How do I pay for PrEP?

PrEP Coverage varies by state and the type of insurance you have. The age requirement to get a prescription for PrEP also varies by state.

Here are ways you can find out how to get more information about PrEP in your state:

Ask your doctor if he prescribes PrEP and if he does, what have his/her/their patients reported.

If you are over 18 years old, call your insurance company and ask about their policies regarding Truvada (PrEP)

Go to a local STD clinical and ask about resources regarding PrEP.

If you have private health insurance: The cost of PrEP is covered by nearly all health insurance plans. Check with your health insurance company about coverage for the medication and about co-pay costs. Gilead, the maker of the medication Truvada that is prescribed for PrEP, has a co-pay assistance program. This assistance program is only available for those 18 years of age and older. Note that the coupon card provided can only be used at participating retail, specialty, or mail-order pharmacies. Availability of these pharmacies can also vary by state.

Visit <https://www.gileadadvancingaccess.com/financial-support/gilead-copay-card> for more information

The Patient Advocate Foundation's Co-Pay Relief Program is also available for PrEP and covers the patient's out-of-pocket costs for the medication up to \$7,500 per year.

Visit <https://www.copays.org/> or or call 1-866-512-3861, Option 1 for assistance.

If you have government insurance (e.g., Medicaid): There are a number of state-based PrEP Assistance Programs.

If you do not have insurance: If you do not have health insurance, you may be able to get PrEP at no or low cost. Gilead has a medication assistance program (MAP) for PrEP. If you are eligible, the program provides

free PrEP to people with limited income and no insurance to cover PrEP. MAP is only available for those 18 years of age and older.

Visit <http://www.gileadcopay.com/> or call 1-877-505-6986 for more information

Where can I find other resources about PrEP?

Click on the links below for more information about PrEP.

<https://www.cdc.gov/hiv/basics/prep.html>

<http://men.prepfacts.org/the-basics/>

<http://men.prepfacts.org/the-questions/>